

Strategic Plan Roundtable Notes - Monday, April 5, 2021
5:00 to 6:30 PM Via Zoom
[Link to Notes Spreadsheet](#)

Introduction: Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent

Introduced four translators for Haitian-Creole, Arabic, Portuguese and Spanish

Elementary: Jenny Graham/Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn/Suzanne Galusi

Middle: PR/Bernadette Ricciardelli

High: Paulette Van der Kloot, Peter Cushing

Special Ed: Suzannah Campbell, and Suzanne Galusi

Paul Teixeira: Room 8, Spanish

Maya: Arabic Room 7

Mr. Bon Bon: Haitian Creole Room 6

Ms. Yung: Portuguese, Room 5

Member McLaughlin: Can we keep a record of how many people are in each room?

Elementary Room

Mitzi Galante, Diane Guarino, Doreen Andrews, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn, Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent, Suzanne Galusi, Shannon Demos, Jenny Graham

8 parents:

Andre Quinas, private school parent

Teresa Fernald, AS/BS

Vaness Farsner, Brooks parent

Amanda Wilson, future Brooks parent

Dipa Shah

Sara Cohen, 3d grade parent at the Brooks

Sharon Hays, Roberts parent

Emily, parent

Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent: Spoke to the Before School/After School parents. We are working on it. We will be speaking of this at Monday night's SC meeting.

Mission/Vision: The Medford Public Schools is a caring educational partnership of school, family and community designed to ensure that all students are afforded a safe and healthy learning environment in which they develop the knowledge, skills and attitudes to reach their full academic and personal potential. This partnership is dedicated to providing all students with a 21st century education that will enable them to be life-long learners and contributors to a diverse and rapidly changing world.

Does MPS' current Mission Statement adequately describe the long range goals you feel MPS should aspire to? Why or why not? What changes do you have?

Sara Cohen: where it says 21st century education, it sounds abstract - is it about pedagogy, technology, values? I feel it could be expressed more explicitly. Make sure we are teaching current ideas about the world - taking in and adapting to new knowledge that we have. Make sure that the curriculum stays up to date with the knowledge. I know that diverse is in the last sentence but it would be nice if education itself draws on diverse strengths in terms of backgrounds, perspectives and skill sets.

Vanessa Farsner: maybe include social emotional support. This vision was probably written before we began using that phrase as often as we do now.

Sharon Hays: Something about teaching children to be critical thinkers. We need to teach kids to analyze information and whether info is true or false.

Does MPS' current Vision statement adequately describe what you feel MPS should achieve in the next X years? Why or why not? What changes do you have?

Sharon Hays: Do we have a number of years?

Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: If you have a suggestion, let us know.

Sharon Hays: It seems like an incomplete plan. But I don't see any actions that we can grab onto. I am a little confused as to where we are in the process of creating the plan. I came across 26 page plans in other districts. What part of the process is this plan? Where does it go after this?

Jenny Graham: From the SC perspective, this plan will serve a lot of purposes. It is a critical part of the process when you hire a new superintendent. As part of the onboarding process to this role, they recommend districts receive this from a new superintendent. The SC has to decide how the budget will be spent - part of the strategic plan will be a mechanism that will help us prioritize spending. This process was started over a year ago. This is the one page level of the plan. There is work being done underneath each umbrella. Before we run in a direction, we want to hear from the community where they want the district to go. Once the SC signs off on a strategic plan, we need to look at how the plan helps to guide us in our decision making. How do we give meaningful direction to the Superintendent and her team? Goal is to get into a rhythm and routine and then be able to evaluate given the same criteria.

Vanessa Farsner: Active members of the school community. We believe the lack of AS/BS care is very unwelcoming. We know that people leave because of this problem. They try to get into charter schools after kindergarten because of this problem. We don't see this focus on the whole child in addressing this need. Our group talks about social emotional needs of students.

How are we meeting the needs of all of our students. We strongly advocate for the expansion of the afterschool programs.

Andre Quina: I agree with Vanessa. We are currently a family not in MPS because of that reason. We couldn't figure out a way to make it work. The Partnership word is an issue in the problem. I feel the partnership with other families instead of with the school system. I emailed and called until we were able to form a group of parents to bring this forward. This is a critical issue and the Superintendent dropped off the call. The vision is irrelevant because I don't have access for my son. That is why this discussion is terribly important. Fundamental issue of accessibility in public schools.

Emily: Leaving after care out of it is a strategic loss for Medford. When students go to charter school, lost revenue. I don't see a timeframe in the vision statement. Maybe a ten year period.

What key actions does MPS need to take to demonstrate forward progress toward our vision in X year? In what timeframe?

Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn What is the capacity for AS at the Brooks?

Shannon Demos: It can vary according to grade level. Staffing is the issue.

Jenny Graham: It is a significant issue at the brooks, more so than the other schools. If you are on the waiting list, you don't come off.

Shannon Demos: Some staff took jobs other places.

Suzanne Galusi: Most districts have not been able to offer after school due to staff.

Precovid: brooks was 150.

Diane Guarino: We didn't add any students due to lack of staff.

Teresa Fernald (in chat): I agree with Sharon Hays' statement.

Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: Any input towards changes in our vision and mission statement?

Cohen: Around the partnership, it would be great to document points of input from families - if we could have ten opportunities to hear from parents. Maybe a survey about how engaged they feel? Is there a whole group that is disenfranchised?

Emily: in terms of achieving the goal, removing the 21st century and replacing it with critical thinking.

Andre: Mission and vision are great. I want to understand how progress is being measured? Targets? What is it currently? Mission doesn't have value unless you have a means of measuring it.

Jenny Graham: That is a really good point.

Andre Quina: needs some quantitative measures.

Teresa: I want to echo what others are saying with measurable quantifiable goals. We are using the After school as an entry point but hope to be part of the community. Transparency. Access to all. I would like to see how this one pager turns into milestones.

Cohen: For things that can be quantified, I agree. Some things don't. Creative thinking can be used to measure the other things. Surveys can help but there has to be other ways. If it can't be counted, it doesn't mean it isn't important.

Vanessa: I agree there are many things that are not a number. By asking parents how it impacts their families, there may not be a numeric response. I am surprised that there are all these parents who care - I haven't seen any working groups soliciting help from the public. If we had a more conversation, maybe we can share that working group conversation.

Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: We do have subcommittees that meet every month. I encourage families to get involved in those meetings. There is more we can do but those meetings are great opportunities for parents to take part in.

Jenny Graham: Those subs meet with more regularity than they did in the past. We are working to solve problems in a more proactive way. The entire committee supports parent engagement in the process.

Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: Those agendas are posted.

Teresa: Transparency - it would be helpful to know what the priorities are.

Andre Quina: What is the accountability to the strategic plan?

Jenny Graham: The SC evaluates the Superintendent on an annual basis. Once this is approved, we will use this to help set goals and then evaluate the Superintendent on that.

Sharon Hays: I am still coming back to the lack of transparency in this document. Where is this going

Attendance / notes

SC: Ruseau

Admin: Tucci, Liu, Downs, Burnham, Ricciardelli, Murphy

Faculty: L. Sanford, Cashin, Irving, Kittredge

Community: Kristen Glionna (parent); Jackie Brown (parent).

MIDDLE SCHOOL NOTES:

Does MPS current mission statement adequately reflect the long-range goals to which MPS should aspire? Why or why not? Input, changes, suggestions?

- It “sounds great” because it’s not long and wordy. Vote of confidence for Tucci and Ricciardelli’s work.
- “Mission” is “what the organization does.” “Vision” is the “long range outlook.” So, do a separate “vision statement” first, and then follow it with a “mission statement.”
 - Second motion to separate the two statements.
- Possible idea of spelling out the actual actions that comprise what we refer to as “21st century.”
- Tinkering with wording: In the mission/vision, change the word “contributor” to “collaborator.”
- Better to say “maximize their potential” instead of “reach their potential.”
- In reality, all learners are NOT going to be societal leaders -- but the goal can be for all individuals to be able to lead in some respect.
- Adding “social responsibility” around covid, and the social justice awakening regarding racial equity
- Determining “what students’ contributions will be”
- Contributions have “individuality.” Every individual has something very important to contribute.
- Is the mission / vision driven by the “core values” of Achievement, Collaboration, Equity, and Support? Maybe we need to place greater emphasis on “equity” as something that drives the mission.

Key actions needed to demonstrate forward progress in our vision?

- To “foster student growth and achievement,” we utilized various teams and make rounds to gather information and then relate back to the measures used.
- Consider alternatives to the word “fostering” -- it doesn’t have an attached measure.
- School Committee members often discuss professional development, and are willing to offer specific trainings that they might want to support for staff.
 - Feedback that we want to implement a more sustainable plan for developing and implementing PD.
 - Creating more “school culture” initiatives.
- We need to work on hiring more POC on staff.
- We do have movements in the area of hiring highly qualified candidates of color.

Middle-school specific:

- Promoting health / wellness, and promoting resources that benefit “the whole child.”
 - Aiming to put back in place Middle School sports (it was highly beneficial).
- Community aspect:
 - Doing more to involve our EL population.
 - Working to involve pastors / churches (among other examples).
 - Aiming to develop greater community unity.
 - Partnering further with the Medford Public Library (as it comes).

HIGH SCHOOL GROUP - Notes

High School Group - Room 3- Paul D’Allewa, Kathy Kreatz, Paulette Van der Kloot, Dr. Nicole Chiesa, Molly Laden, Faiza Khan, and Maria D’Orsi.

Lisa Evangelista - Note Taker - Dr. Chiesa - Time Keeper.

NO Parents/caregivers participated

Member Van der Kloot - So how many in this room were in the planning process of this plan?

Mr. D'Alleva - initially myself, Dr. Cushing, Dr. Ricciardelli, Suzannah Campbell, and Stacey Schulman -met and worked on the strategic plan and presented it in the chamber in the initial stages of the document.

Dr. Cushing - At the time, we were looking for a committed group due to time that it would involve.

Member Van der Kloot - I think, overall we need to include the words flexible and resilience

Mr. D'Alleva - Our focus is on the whole child - a lot of our mission & vision came from that foundation - I agree Paulette, at MHS I often state flexibility and forgiveness daily!

Member Van der Kloot - MPS Mission Statement - "The Medford Public Schools is a caring educational partnership of school, family and community designed to ensure that all students are afforded a safe and healthy learning environment in which they develop the knowledge, skills, and attitudes to reach their full academic and personal potential. This partnership is dedicated to providing all students with a 21st century education that will enable them to be life-long learners and contributors to a diverse and rapidly changing world". Let's discuss this

Ms. D'Orsi - attitudes? What does that mean? I think that's a little too personal - not sure we have ability to change that ... just my thought

Mr. D'Alleva - can you elaborate?

Maria D - attitudes - developing an attitude is different from developing a skill or a vision - not the right word for that particular sentence

Member Van der Kloot - Mindset might be a better word?

Mr. D'Alleva - I like that Paulette!

Dr. Cushing - in full honesty, full transparency - it was more to inform the work we did - the 4 big buckets - we felt the mission work was larger - a whole another piece of the puzzle

Mr. D'Alleva - hearing what Maria just said - a different perspective is always helpful - I agree - Mindset might fit better.

Member Van der Kloot - students have to believe in themselves

Ms. D'Orsi - I like the word - motivation

Dr. Cushing - our MPS mission statement might be too long - should be a 60 second pitch - brief and all encompassing as possible -

Member Van der Kloot - this is steeped in educational wording - What about Great kids, great opportunities, great staff - what are we really talking about?

Mr. D'Alleva - My wife worked at Boston Public and they had a catch phrase - "every student, everyday" - it was piece of their mission statement - when I was at the Andrews - "Excellence through responsibility and respect" - centered the conversation in many ways - the more that I look at the statement - the vision and mission are kind of meshed together - may need to particle it out - at MHS we have been working on it regarding the mission - but now we have to figure it out for the district

Dr. Cushing - in a way, once this mission statement is set - all of the other schools mission statement should work off of the main one

Dr. Chiesa - 20 minutes per question, correct?

Mr. D'Alleva - yes

Member Van der Kloot - express our goals in far fewer words, but we haven't suggested any as yet ...

Dr. Cushing - partnership - we want a partnership - but is it really a partnership when it's only active via the school, not the families?

Member Van der Kloot - collaborative relationship?

Dr. Cushing - we need to stop splitting the hairs

Dr. Chiesa - partnership is more like a law firm - I like collaboration

Member Van der Kloot - I like collaborative relationship

Mr. D'Alleva - As we look at Question 1 - Does MPS current mission statement adequately describe the long range goals you feel MPS should aspire to? Why or why not? What changes or suggestions do you have?

Dr. Chiesa - the mission statement outlines where we are heading, but does it encompass all of our goals? - maybe look at the mission and what does it say? What is it missing?

Member Van der Kloot - fostering ...student growth, collaborative relationships, safe & support learning - equitable education ... But, again, what makes it specific to Medford? That is a piece that needs to be defined for me. Maybe one of the links may answer that? Is the statement too formal ?

Mr. D'Alleva - Idea is that we have these things in place - Stacey Schulman actively participated in this process - Where objectives are- Have mission and vision and the objectives are to align with that - achievement, collaborative, equitable, safe/supportive - Based off this initial statement

Dr. Chiesa - 3 minutes left on this question

Member Van der Kloot - there is nothing wrong with it, but not concise or memorable to Medford in particular - all the points in the plan are great, what makes it stand out? What makes it Medford's plan? Unique to Medford - special to Medford?

Dr. Chiesa - Maybe add in the Mustang Way ?

Member Van der Kloot - we would know that, but a new to the community person wouldn't know what the Mustang Way means - that has to be worked on

Mr. D'Alleva - We need a tagline - like the "every student, everyday" quote - We have to get a catch phrase out of the statement so everyone in community understands it

Dr. Chiesa - we are at time

Special Education Notes

[LINK to spreadsheet](#)

BACK TO LARGER GROUP

Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent: I didn't go into all of the groupings just yet but wanted to be able to take the opportunity to hear from each group. Let's start with Special Education. 3 minutes per group to share highlight.

Special Education: Member McLaughlin: We talked about what are the measurable benchmarks in each level? How is the data going to demonstrate that? Having more specificity about what it means to be successful in the 21st century. When we say all students, what does that mean? We talked about partnerships that were formed this year during the pandemic.

High School: Paulette Van der Kloot worked on revisions to the draft.

Paulette Van der Kloot: MPS safe and equitable learning environments.....

A lot of the conversation was from Boston, every student, every day.

Paul D'Alleva: Taking the vision statement and turning it into a catchphrase. Parsing it down. Marice always uses "in partnership for children".

Paulette Van der Kloot: Key phrases that came up.....school environment is so important to nurture our kids. Adaptability, resilience.

Middle School: Paul Ruseau

A few things: serious discussion whether the mission and vision need to be split. A number of people agreed with that. Some of the aces seem absent. 21st century education - what does that mean? That phraseology doesn't mean anything to most people. Three words that need more: reached, fostering feels unmeasurable and vague.

Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent: Is there a word besides "fostering"?

Paul Ruseau: There was not a better word. We can say we offer something but that doesn't mean it is available to everybody. Was it delivered or received? Fostering doesn't express taking responsibility for achieving the goal.

Jenny Graham: Elementary School Group

We had a good conversation about a number of things. A lot of passion about BS/AS being made available to all who need it. Access to that means progress. 21st century sounds abstract. The notion of wanting to insure that we are creating critical thinkers. Being able to understand what is real and what is not. The education we provide needs to draw from diverse skills and backgrounds. Making sure curriculum is rigorous and up to date, reflecting current thinking across the world. Overwhelming comment about plan feeling incomplete at the moment. Trying to connect the dots to the components attached to the one pager. How do we measure if we are making progress? Just because it can't be quantified doesn't mean it can be measured? We haven't had meetings like this in the past - zoom has enabled us to connect more than in the past.

Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: Family engagement is important.

Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent: One probing question to Member Graham: when you talk about quantifiable. Do you have an example of something quantifiable and something not.

Jenny Graham: With MCAS you can measure but in contrast but the Fine arts don't attach to an MCAS score?

Melanie McLaughlin: Regarding the data, the quantifiable piece can be looking at "all students" - disaggregating around subgroups and reporting that out.

Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent: we didn't have any EL participation in the language groups. Perhaps they will join tomorrow from 6 to 7:30. The Strategic plan is a very important document for us to have. It is a living breathing document that will continue to grow and evolve. Thanks to all of you who joined us to help us make improvements to the Strategic Plan.

ROLL: Jenny Graham, Kathy Kreatz, Melanie McLaughlin, Paul Ruseau, Paulette Van der Kloot, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: 6 present, one absent.

Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn; tomorrow's session is 6 to 7:30.

Motion to adjourn: Melanie McLaughlin, Paulette Van der Kloot

ROLL: Jenny Graham, Kathy Kreatz, Melanie McLaughlin, Paul Ruseau, Paulette Van der Kloot, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: motion to adjourn approved.